

Virginians Only Triple-A Farm?

Nothing Definite---MacPhail; Yankee-Denver Split Talked

By ANDY McCUTCHEON

Yankee personnel director Lee MacPhail today put a temporary damper on reports that Denver is out of the New York farm system and that the Virginians are in as the American League champions' one-and-only triple-A outpost.

"There is nothing definite at this time," said MacPhail in regard to reports from Denver that the Bears' working agreement with the New York Yankees had been terminated.

"Our working agreements with both Denver and Richmond are not subject for renewal until December 15," said MacPhail by phone from his office in New York.

He said that the Yankees had not dropped the Bears and that he had received no indication from Denver that the American Association club wanted out of the New York farm system.

MacPhail did say that the

Yankees were in the process of studying their farm system and it has passed the point of speculation that they weren't particularly happy with the way things went last season.

The Virginians finished sixth in the International League and Denver barely hung on in the first division of the American Association after a fast start. New Orleans finished in the Class AA Southern Association cellar.

Binghamton had a bad time of it in the Class A Eastern League and it's no secret that the Yankees, who go more for quality than quantity in their farm program, felt their minor league talent was spread a little too thin.

If the answer to the Yankees' problem is a cutback to one triple-A team—which would mean more talent for the lower farms—the Virginians will go all out to be that one team.

Denver did fire its manager, Andy Cohen, yesterday and a newspaper, the Rocky Mountain News, said the Bears and the Yankees were through, but club president Robert S. Howsam declined to comment.

Denver became a member of the New York system four years ago by purchasing the Yankees' Kansas City franchise in the American Association for \$75,000 when the old Philadelphia Athletics moved westward.

The Bears finished third in 1955 and second in 1956 and 1957, when they also won the league playoffs and the Little World Series at the expense of the Buffalo team in the IL.

If the Yankees have to decide between Denver and Richmond for their one triple-A farm, it would appear that the Virginians' chances are as good—if not better—than the Bears.

For one thing, the IL is a

much more stable baseball league than the American Association. For another, Richmond can be reached from the New York front office much more quickly than Denver.

And third, the altitude at Denver has forced the Yankees to revise the averages of their farmhands with the Bears. Curves don't curve and pop flies carry over the fence for home runs in the light Denver air.

The Virginians became a member of the New York farm system with a limited working agreement for the 1955 season, when they finished fifth. It became a full agreement in 1956 and they finished third.

They were sixth this past season when injuries plagued the team. In fact, injuries hit throughout the Yankee system and there weren't enough replacements to go around.